

Standing at your desk to undo a day of sitting

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 1 myth · 8 sources · [cheatgrid.com](#)

Standing at your desk barely changes how much energy you burn, and it doesn't solve your sitting problem by itself. Raising the desk can still feel like you've done something, even on days you barely used it.

THE GOAL

You give each stretch of standing a real time limit and some movement inside it, then keep sitting, not standing, as the actual base of your day.

CHECKLIST

You reach for the button that raises your desk.

- ☐ Set a timer before you start, something under the point where standing starts to ache, try twenty-five to thirty minutes.
- ☐ Re-check your monitor and keyboard height for standing before you start typing.
- ☐ Plan one movement break for partway through: a few chair stands or a short lap around the room.
- ☐ Write down how long you stand this time, wherever you already track it.
- ☐ If your feet or lower back start to ache before the timer's done, lower the desk right then instead of waiting it out.
- ☐ If the timer goes off first, lower the desk and sit, even if you feel like you could keep going.
- ☐ If what you notice is sharp pain or visible swelling instead of ordinary tiredness, stop standing there for the rest of the day.
- ☐ Once you're sitting again, pick a fixed point later, like your next call, where you'll stand again.
- ☐ If work pulled you away today, start tomorrow's stint at the same planned length, not longer to make up for it.
- ☐ In the evening, pick one standing or moving thing, like taking one call on your feet, so the switch doesn't stop at your desk.
- ☐ At the end of the week, check your total against a two-to-four-hour daily range and adjust it by minutes, not by doubling it.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 A real sit-stand desk, used six months, didn't cut how much workers sat. Sensors tracked them instead of surveys.
- 2 Standing without a break for more than about forty minutes is where the trouble usually starts.
- 3 Sitting less at your desk doesn't guarantee you sit less overall. In one trial, office workers who cut sitting at work by about half an hour went on to sit roughly twenty minutes more at home, though that home rise wasn't statistically confirmed.

What getting the desk has actually changed

KNOW

A real sit-stand desk, used six months, didn't cut how much workers sat. Sensors tracked them instead of surveys.

Work got busier as the months went on, and that crowded out the new habit for some of the group, by the trial's own account. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Standing barely burns more than sitting does. That's about nine calories an hour, one stalk of celery.

The comparison was resting, sitting and standing rates in a lab, not a workout, so the gap between them was always going to be small. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Office workers' actual use of the new desk fell over six months, from about five days a week at first to three by the end.

Even on days workers did stand, the length of each stretch fell too, from twenty to thirty minutes down to ten to twenty. [Source 2](#)

How long to actually stand, and how to break it up

RULE

Standing without a break for more than about forty minutes is where the trouble usually starts.

Standing still can let blood pool in your legs, which may add to that ache, one review found. [Source 3](#)

DON'T

These desks were never designed around standing instead of sitting all day. The actual recommendation was to work up to about two hours of standing, then four, not to replace sitting outright.

The same expert panel behind that recommendation also warned that standing still for long unbroken stretches carries its own risks, just like sitting does. [Source 4](#)

DO

A few chair stands or a short walk lowers your after-meal blood sugar response more than sitting straight through does.

Moving your muscles may trigger blood flow and sugar uptake that sitting still doesn't, though the exact mechanism is still unconfirmed. [Source 5](#)

What this does and doesn't fix

KNOW

Sitting less at your desk doesn't guarantee you sit less overall. In one trial, office workers who cut sitting at work by about half an hour went on to sit roughly twenty minutes more at home, though that home rise wasn't statistically confirmed.

The trial's own authors point to this as one reason sit-stand results vary so much between studies: what happens after work undoes some of it. [Source 6](#)

KNOW

Six months of real use eased workers' aches and end-of-day tiredness. The gain over doing nothing wasn't clearly proven, though.

The trial's own authors flagged this directly: the gap wasn't clearly better than the group that changed nothing. [Source 7](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

A standing desk is the fix for the back pain from a desk job.

ACTUALLY

Research comparing standing and sitting directly during desk work found office workers had just as much back pain standing for long stretches as sitting for them. Both need breaking up, not swapping. [Source 8](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.westmont.edu/faculty-research/standing-your-desk-burns-few-additional-calories>
2. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC11492196/>
3. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/28863296/>
4. <https://shura.shu.ac.uk/11023/3/Copeland%20Sedentary%20office.pdf>
5. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/33180640/>
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7. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/39404230/>

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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Sitting and moving through the day at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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